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RAIL GAUGE AND GHOSTS

The Little Trains, a Few with Oxen on Them

The iron web was spreading across the subcontinent at a rapid pace. It is important to note that at this juncture, the railways in India saw the historic introduction of a number of short lines and trains of multiple gauges and dimensions. This is significant from today's point of view, as the Ministry of Railways is on a mission to convert all the existing short lines into the main line. In a few years from now, I fear, there will be no short lines to boast of, except those with tourist interest, listed as heritage, and probably a few very remote ones.

With small trains and short lines, romance and utility went hand in hand. Let's see how it came to be, but before that, let's understand track gauge. It can be complicated for a lay person to understand, but let me try and explain it simply. The beauty is in its simplicity .

If I were to say that imperial Roman war chariots and horses' behinds had something to do with the space between the two rails of a track, I would be ridiculed or ignored.

But there is actually an urban legend that claims there is a connection—unsubstantiated, but very often quoted.

It tells you a story, and, in the process, explains what a gauge is. The standard distance between the two rails of a track—4 feet 8½ inches—is so because the horse tramways that ran prior to the railways had been of the same width. The tramways were built using the same tools as used for horse wagons, and that was how wide the wagon wheels were spaced. Why? Because the old roads in England had ruts that the wheels had to fit into.